





KARKHANA
A Studio in Rajasthan
by Waswo X. Waswo
MAPIN PUBLISHING
₹2,950; 247 pages

and fauna, one for the borders, etc) in a model that replicates a typical medieval atelier (a *karkhana*), the printing of the editions of the final digital images made from the composite pictures, the construction of the frames, and so on.

Parting the gorgeously rendered foliage that's present in so many of the images, one can see that WXW's chief subject is himself; whatever comment on the world or on art and visual perception a WXW work might make, it makes it through the lens, as it were, of the artist's constant presence in the image. In this, WXW owes a debt to various western artists: as a sort of anti-Frida Kahlo/ Cindy Sherman; not so much Chuck Close, who mined his own face across a painting career, as William Wegman, who photographed his Weimaraner dogs in different contexts (here, of course, WXW becomes his own Weimaraner). For any art lover, the other fun game to play is spot-the-quotation; and indeed the Waswo delicatessen has a wide selection of *hommage* on display, from Indian mythology to Tantra, to Husain, Warhol and Koons.

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Ultimately, one is left with two reactions: the first is that one has observed at length an elephant gracefully bathing itself in the river of its own admiration; the erotics signalled in several of the images here take us not to an examination of any desire of the other but a sort of onanimagism, a möbius strip of self-regard. Secondly, whatever the tongue-in-cheek intentions towards critiquing the Orientalist gaze, the constant presence of the jovial or alarmed, clueless, suited white man actually ends up reinforcing the colonial, totally undercutting the flagged undercutting. The lovely filigree of detail in the images makes all this somewhat bearable, but as you close the book you feel as though you have sampled a heavy buffet of quite nice dishes that all taste vaguely similar. ■

–Ruchir Joshi

Courtesy: TALWAR GALLERY, NEW YORK | NEW DELHI



he notes that the work presented an alternative understanding of how paint can be applied, figures rendered and our ordinary realities represented on canvas–all of which are questions Dodiya has continued to attend to in his own practice.

One volume of *Moving Focus* features such anecdotes and analyses alongside images while the other volume provides large reproductions of the artworks for closer study. There are also a number of short essays addressing canon-formation and institution-building in India and abroad accompanied by a lively panel discussion with six of the nominators. This discussion along with Chatterjee's two essays–one on collecting and the other on memory and memorialising–covers a vast terrain and touches upon subjects that may otherwise escape the general reader, such as the decisive role of the art market in consolidating the significance and visibility of the Progressive Artists' Group, or the impact of museum shows in the US and UK in reorienting the canon within the country, and the oft-repeated but inaccurate story of the fragmentation of art-making into installation as a response to the fragmentation of society with the rise of Hindutva in the 1990s.



MOVING FOCUS, INDIA
New Perspectives on Modern & Contemporary Art
by Mortimer Chatterjee
ACC ART BOOKS
₹25,000; 620 pages

While many historical, political and formal turns and currents within art in India emerge in reading the book, backwards and forwards, no claim to a complete or total understanding of the field is made. What *Moving Focus* does make us aware of, though, is that most of the art that matters to various well-known practitioners is largely out of sight and reach of the public, turning these printed lists into their only available galleries. Although the collectors were deliberately left out of the group of nominators, they haunt the book in that they hold the keys to much of the art featured in it. The book itself could not have been made without the support of collectors Deepak and Priya Tanna. ■

–Zeenat Nagree